

Superstitions Are Still a Baseball Tradition

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Call it superstition, idiosyncrasy or flakiness, but baseball players still follow signs, hunches and beliefs.

Perhaps there are no major leaguers today who can match Bobo Newsom, the meticulous moundman who earned the tag of the "house-keeper" back in the 1930s, '40s and '50s.

Bobo insisted on a tidy shop. Only the resin bag was acceptable to the eccentric right-handed pitcher.

One afternoon Old Bobo was in the groove, throwing strikes and blanks until an enemy dropped a handful of little pieces of paper on the mound as he trotted in to the dugout.

Bobo refused to pitch until the "mess" was eliminated. Newsom's pitching that day fell into almost as many pieces as the paper in the sabotage act.

None of the Royals approaches Bobo and some other superstitious characters of the past.

But if you ever gain access to the Royals' bullpen, don't mess around with Steve Mingori's glove.

"Before I go to the pen I always pick out a comfortable ball," explained the little relief pitcher. I leave my glove with the ball in it at the same spot every night. The others know not to mess with it. It would upset me."

Mingori always puts his uniform on in the same sequence. Included is a rather worn gray T-shirt.

"It's just a comfortable pattern," Mingori said. "I'd be upset without this shirt, like a carpenter with somebody else's hammer."

Before Dennis Leonard goes to the mound every inning he goes through a ritual that began early in the season when the weather was cool. After taking a swallow of water he washes his face with a dab or two, then spits out the remaining water on the top step of the dugout.

"Early I couldn't sweat out there because it was cool," the young pitcher said. "So I got in the habit of doing the routine. If I think it helps me—that's good. I'm particular about my game food, too. Before I pitch a night game I'll always have steak and green beans, bacon and eggs before a day game."

Before every pitching start Steve Busby loses himself in a crossword puzzle.

"Superstition?" said Busby. "I don't think so. I do crossword puzzles quite a bit. Before I pitch the puzzle relaxes me physically but keeps my mind active. Now that pitchers don't take hitting practice they have to have something to occupy themselves before a game."

Paul Splittorf, like many other pitchers and some managers, evades the foul lines when going to or leaving the mound.

"But I didn't even realize that until a neighbor told me," he said. "But if I'm

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hot, going good, I'll stay with the same pair of spikes, even though they're worn out. They can get pretty shabby."

Galen Cisco has no superstitions as the Royals' pitching coach.

As a player Cisco did.

"Seems sorta silly now," Cisco said, "but I didn't want anybody touching my glove on the bench. I always hit the chalk line on the way to the mound and I always sat in the same place on the bench. I always got the place some way, even if I had to get a conversation going with the next guy and move somebody out. I used to think it was a bad omen when the catcher threw the ball into center field on his throw to second just before the start of the inning. That really irritated me."

Hai McRae has been wearing the same T-shirt, jeans and tennis shoes to the ball park for 10 days.

"If I do it another four or five days I guess you can call it a superstition," said the Royals' slugger. "You do things like this and people think you're flaky. People don't want to be called that."

Walt Alston and Sparky Anderson are line-skipppers. Both National League managers will do a goose-step—or any step they need—to miss stepping on the foul line when they visit the pitcher's mound. Mike Cuellar of Baltimore has the same superstition. Not only does he jump over the line, but he always waits until his catcher is out there before he goes to the mound.

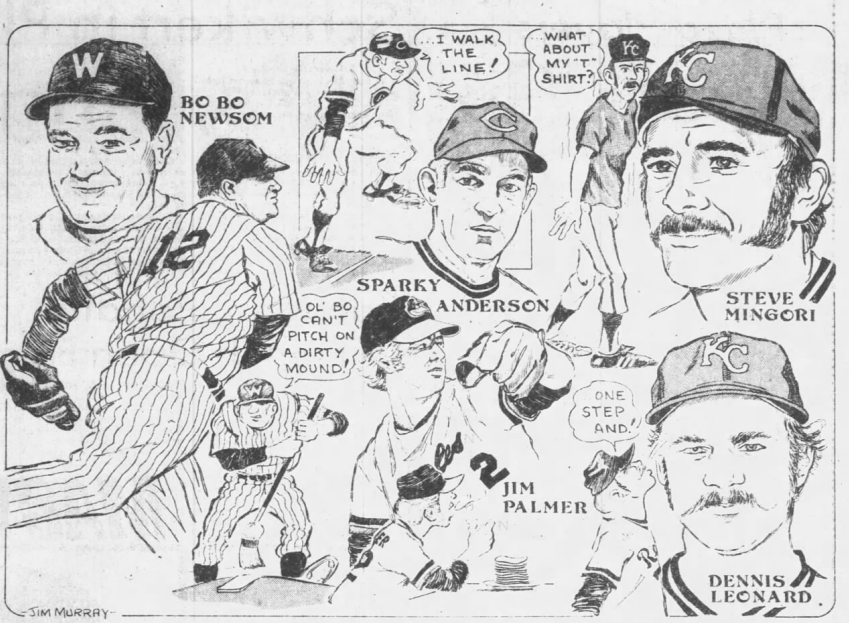
Whitney Herzog, the Royals' manager, also had a superstition as a player.

"When I'd have a good game," he said, "I'd have my wife cook the same meal as the day before and I'd dress the same. But I never had to go through it three days in a row. The other clubs never kept sending the same pitcher out there against me."

Jim Palmer of the Orioles believes pancakes for breakfast means a victory on the pitching mound. Vic Raschi and Spad Chandler, a couple of pitchers with the New York Yankees when they were the perennial world champions, believed in solitude.

On nonpitching days the two were outgoing, friendly people. On their starting days they weren't.

"Chandler was the most irritable person in the world the days he was starting," said Ralph Houk, now Detroit's manager. "Other days he was Mr. Nice Guy. Raschi refused to have a picture taken or talk to anyone before a game. He used to get more than upset about pictures, downright belligerent. Guess he just wanted to focus on



nothing but the game."

On the same Yankee club shortstop Phil Rizzuto had to have two pieces of gum, one for chewing and the other for the button of his cap.

Back in his American Association days with Columbus, Joe Schultz received an order from his manager, Burt Shotton.

"Andy Cohen was coming up to hit," said Schultz, now a Detroit coach. "I was catching. Shotton told me to walk around Cohen every time he came up to hit. So I did, and Cohen got all upset, walked out of the box. When he got back in he wasn't in any condition to hit."

Probably the most superstitious manager in the history of baseball was Johnny Neun. The summer of '42 was an interesting one for the Kansas City Blues, who won the American Association pennant.

Neun wouldn't leave his manager's room at old Blues Stadium to go to the field until everything was in perfect order, and that put pressure on the clubhouse boy. Some days or nights Neun would abort his departure from the small room six or seven times, going back to move an article into its proper place.

Neun, who also had a proper sequence for putting on his uniform and never deviated from it, believed that spitting three times against the dugout wall each time before his team came to bat was good luck.

In order to make Neun's job more pleasant the clubhouse boy that season drew a bullseye above the water cooler. Neun never thanked him formally, but you could detect his sense of appreciation.

Through the years baseball probably has had many more superstitions. How many ball players, young, old, amateur or professional believed that any time you found a hairpin you had a base hit coming?

"I forgot about that early in my career," said Harry Craft the other day. "My first year, I think it was my first week as a pro I found a big package of hairpins next to a park bench. I figured I'd never get that many base hits."

"But there still are ball players who believe in the hairpin thing," said Craft, now a super scout. "I don't think there are as many superstitious players these days. They're thinking more of money."

Still baseball always will have its superstitions.

